Indian population today.[10] Did the Aryans mentioned in the Vedas arrive from the north-west or were they indigenous to India, to the extent that they trace their roots from some other source? The genetic evidence from the 2009 *Nature* study suggests strong similarities between north Indians and their western neighbours, but could the migrations have taken place *from* India to the west and not vice-versa? And what about the origins of the ASI (not to be confused with the Archaeological Survey of India) and the tribes of the Andaman and Nicobar Islands (not to be confused with ANI)? While the balance of evidence currently points towards migration streams from the north-west to explain the appearance of ANIs and ASIs in the Indian subcontinent, these questions are likely to be answered more substantively only over the course of the 21st century through inter-disciplinary research spanning genetics, anthropology, linguistics, archaeology and the like.

Beyond the Aryan migration debate, migrations in India were historically shaped by specific geographical conditions and the technology available at different times to remould or surpass them. The mighty Himalayan Range in the north and north-east formed a natural barrier between China and the Indian subcontinent as did the Hindu Kush Range in the north-west against central Asia. The passes in the north-west mountains such as Bolan, Gomal and Khyber passes were the keyholes to unlocking entry into India for centuries and were used more often than the Himalayan passes as they were less snowbound. The passes would also affect the fate of towns such as Taxila, Kabul and Peshawar located in the vicinity.

The triangular peninsular region of the subcontinent consists of the land below the Vindhya Range and Narmada River in central India, including the Deccan Plateau made up of volcanic rock bounded on two sides by the Western and Eastern Ghats. The undulating nature of the plateau, the presence of a few navigable rivers or passes connecting the coasts gave it an isolated landlocked status for much of ancient Indian history, when the means for migration were still primitive. And while historical texts allude to the *dakshinapatha*, or the southern route through the peninsula, the northern rim of the Deccan Plateau around the Vindhyas itself became a sort of cultural barrier, demarcating the north from the south.